

Goats with big appetites are front-line workers in fire prevention

By The Washington Post, adapted by Newsela staff on 07.17.22

Word Count **683**

Level **840L**



The city of West Sacramento, California, rented 400 goats in the spring to eat weeds and tall grass to prevent wildfires. Photo: Hannah Padilla/Washington Post Hannah Padilla/City of West Sacramento

In May 2022, there was a 10-acre wildfire in West Sacramento, California. The fire was spreading quickly toward an apartment building. Then all of a sudden, the flames went out, and the building was saved.

It seemed like a miracle, but it was actually the work of 400 hungry goats. The goats had eaten most of the dry plants in the area. The fire stopped because there was nothing else to burn, saving a neighborhood of more than 250 homes.

"Goats are really hard workers. They'll eat anything," said Paul Hosley. He works for the city of West Sacramento.

The city had let the goats loose a few weeks before the fire. They ate about two football fields worth of dry plants every day. That created a firebreak or an open space with no plants. The fire had nothing to burn, so it stopped spreading.

Hosley says the goats are great for the environment. The people of West Sacramento love them, too.

Goats Will Even Eat Poisonous Weeds

West Sacramento has used the goats to clear tall weeds for eight years. This method of removing weeds is better for the environment than other ways.

Hosley says the goats are helpful because they can reach places a lawn mower cannot. The goats also eat anything. Hosley says they will even eat poisonous weeds and stand on their back legs to eat leaves from trees.

Many cities use goats to help prevent fires. However, other places also use goats to get rid of invasive plants. Invasive plants are those that grow in places where they shouldn't. Those plants cause problems for the other plants and animals in that area.

The Riverside Park Conservancy is a group that takes care of Riverside Park in New York City. They use goats to get rid of invasive plants.

The goats have been coming to Riverside Park for three years. John Herrold is the president of the Riverside Park Conservancy. He says the goats come from a farm in upstate New York and they love the sweet taste of the poisonous plants.



"We're thrilled to have the goats' help again," Herrold said. "Everyone benefits from their presence. The goats get to enjoy the park's weeds, the park's natural environment is improved, and New Yorkers get to see goats in their local park."

"They're Sweet-Natured And They're Hard Workers"

Mary Bowen lives in Maryland and has a herd of 75 goats. She rents them out to cities that want to clear out invasive plants. Bowen says goats are a more natural way to get rid of the plants because they don't harm the soil.

When she travels, Bowen uses an electric fence. This ensures that the goats stay focused on eating the right weeds and leaves. After a long day munching everything in sight, her goats lie down for a long rest.

"They're sweet-natured and they're hard workers," she said. "I'm blessed to live my life with them."

In Colorado, Lani Malmberg and her son Donny Benz have a herd of about 1,200 goats. They have traveled to 17 states to create firebreaks and remove noxious plants. Noxious plants are harmful to the environment and the soil.

Two years ago, Malmberg helped start the Goatapelli Foundation. It is an organization that teaches people how to work with goats in their communities.

Malmberg believes goats are a great tool for preventing fires and saving water. She says that goats use less water than firefighters. They also eat noxious plants that help fires spread faster.

Malmberg thinks this will be a busy season for her herd of goats. The fires are getting worse every year because of climate change, she said. The goats are a great way to help prevent fires.

"There is no machine out there that can do what a goat can do," she said.

